

COLLEGE FOOTBALL CONCESSIONS • REPORT • OCTOBER 1, 2026

HAPPY HOUR AND FAN FIRST PRICING IN COLLEGE FOOTBALL

Tennessee's first hour at half price sparked a look at how schools price concessions and which approaches might work best.



9

PRICING PROGRAMS

7

SCHOOLS

4

PRICING MODELS

Summary

On Sept 30, Tennessee athletic director Danny White made Happy Hour at Neyland Stadium the policy for the rest of the season: concessions are half price for the first hour after gates open. The move sparked this analysis, which goes deeper on how college programs approach concession pricing, what each approach is built to do and how a school could tell which one works best for its fans.

4 daysTHE PILOT

A single pilot game against Texas became a season policy in four days.

At the Sept 26 pilot, gates opened 3 hours before kickoff and every stand sold at half price for the first hour. Auburn on Oct 3 is the first game under the new policy.

2xTHE MATH

At half price, the hour needs twice the units to hold revenue.

At a \$15 price and \$5 cost per unit, it needs four times the units to hold contribution. Neyland sold about \$615K of alcohol per home game in 2025. Every 10% of units sold at half price with no new volume gives up about \$31K.

1 of 3THE FAN VIEW

Value seekers and fans near the gates are the most likely to come in earlier.

Tailgaters already paid for their drinks. Fans who come for warmups and the band already arrive early, so the discount mostly lowers the price of what they would buy anyway.

9HOW IT COMPARES

Seven schools run nine pricing programs, and they do different jobs.

Happy hours move spending earlier. Value menus at Texas, Baylor and West Virginia keep hot dogs, popcorn and soft drinks between \$2 and \$4 all game, and Texas sells \$5 Bud Light. Coastal Carolina includes food with the ticket.

+16%THE EVIDENCE

Earlier programs report gains. None isolates the price change.

Atlanta reported 16% higher spend per fan in 2017, the year its new stadium opened. Coastal Carolina and Texas report crowds and program length, not measured price effects.

1 hrWHAT TO MEASURE

The first number to read is the share of fans scanned an hour before kickoff.

Read it with spend per fan across the game and contribution, against the closest 2025 game by kickoff slot, opponent and weather. Tennessee's Sept 26 pilot against Texas ran under Secret Service screening, so it says little about the discount.

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One discount, different jobs

The four ways schools discount concessions, and the job each one is built to do.

Happy hour

Job: move spending earlier



Tennessee

50% off concession stands for the first hour after gates open



Texas

\$5 domestic, \$6.50 premium beer at five pregame venues

Value menu

Job: keep the basics affordable



Texas

\$3 popcorn and water, \$4 hot dogs, \$5 nachos and Bud Light, \$6 Corona



Baylor

\$2 popcorn and 16 oz drink, \$4 hot dog and pretzel, \$5 nachos



West Virginia

Fan First pricing: \$3 popcorn, drink and water, \$3.50 pepperoni roll



Texas A&M

\$1 off hot dogs, nachos and candy; new \$6 popcorn

Included food

Job: add value to the ticket



Coastal Carolina

Hot dog, nachos, popcorn and drink per visit, through Q3

Loyalty discount

Job: reward members and ticket holders



West Virginia

10% off the first order, season ticket holders



South Carolina

10% off select items, members and students

4

pricing models

Tennessee's offer is a timing tool that moves spending into the first hour. Value menus at Texas, Baylor and West Virginia lower prices all game, and Texas puts \$5 Bud Light on its menu.

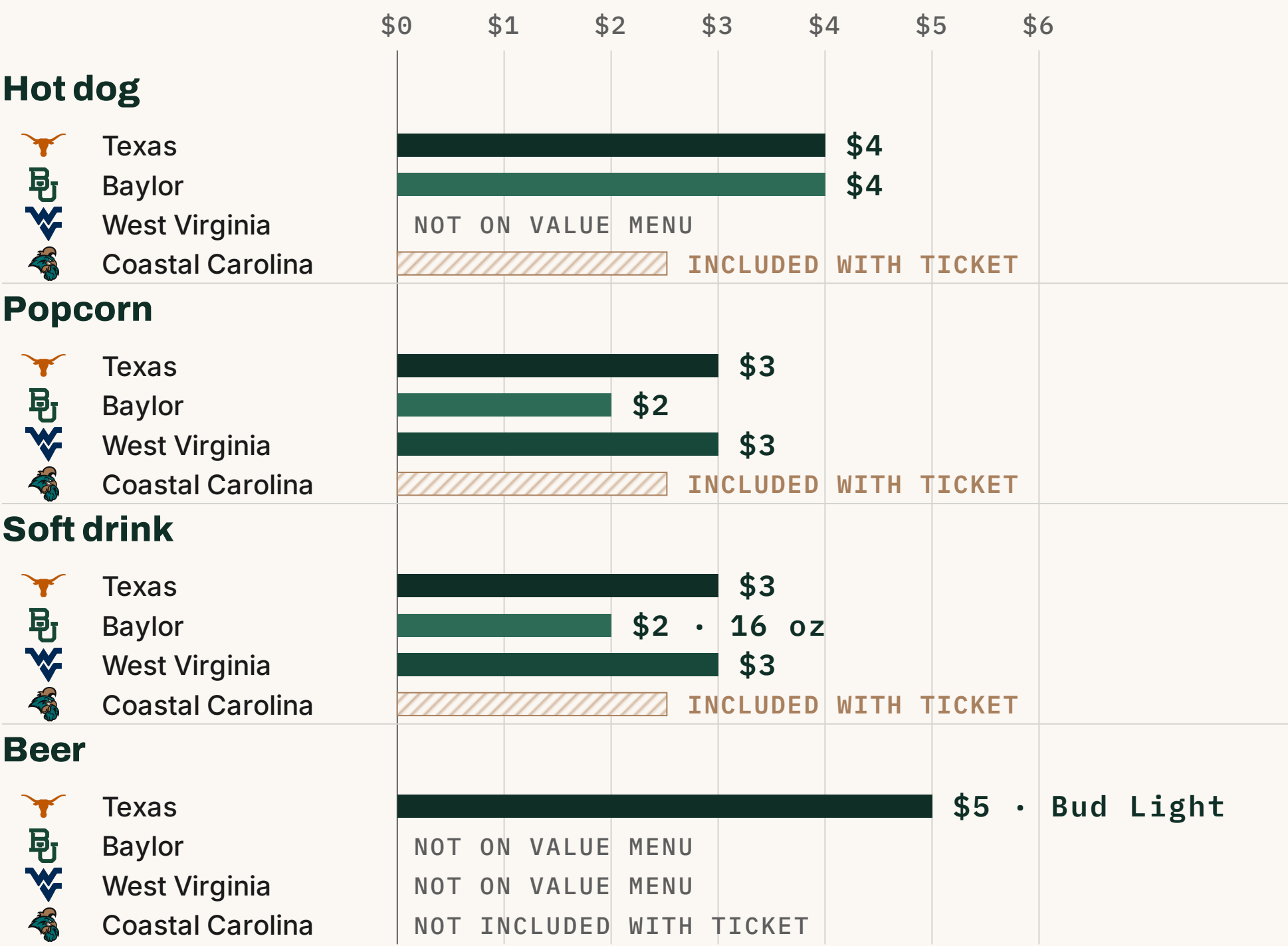
HOW TO READ IT

Nine pricing programs at seven schools, grouped by model: happy hour, value menu, included food and loyalty discount. Each band names the commercial job that model does.

Sources: On3 (Sept 30, 2026); Texas Athletics (gameday concessions; Sept 1, 2026); Baylor (Feb 18, 2026); WVU (Aug 13, 2026); Coastal Carolina (Aug 18, 2026); 12th Man (Aug 31, 2026); South Carolina (Aug 20, 2026). Commercial purpose is analysis, not a reported outcome.

What the basics cost

Value menu prices for the most common items at four schools.



\$5

Bud Light at Texas, all game

The basics cost \$2 to \$4 on every value menu. Texas is the only school here with beer on its value menu: \$5 Bud Light all game, the same price as domestic beer at its outdoor happy hour.

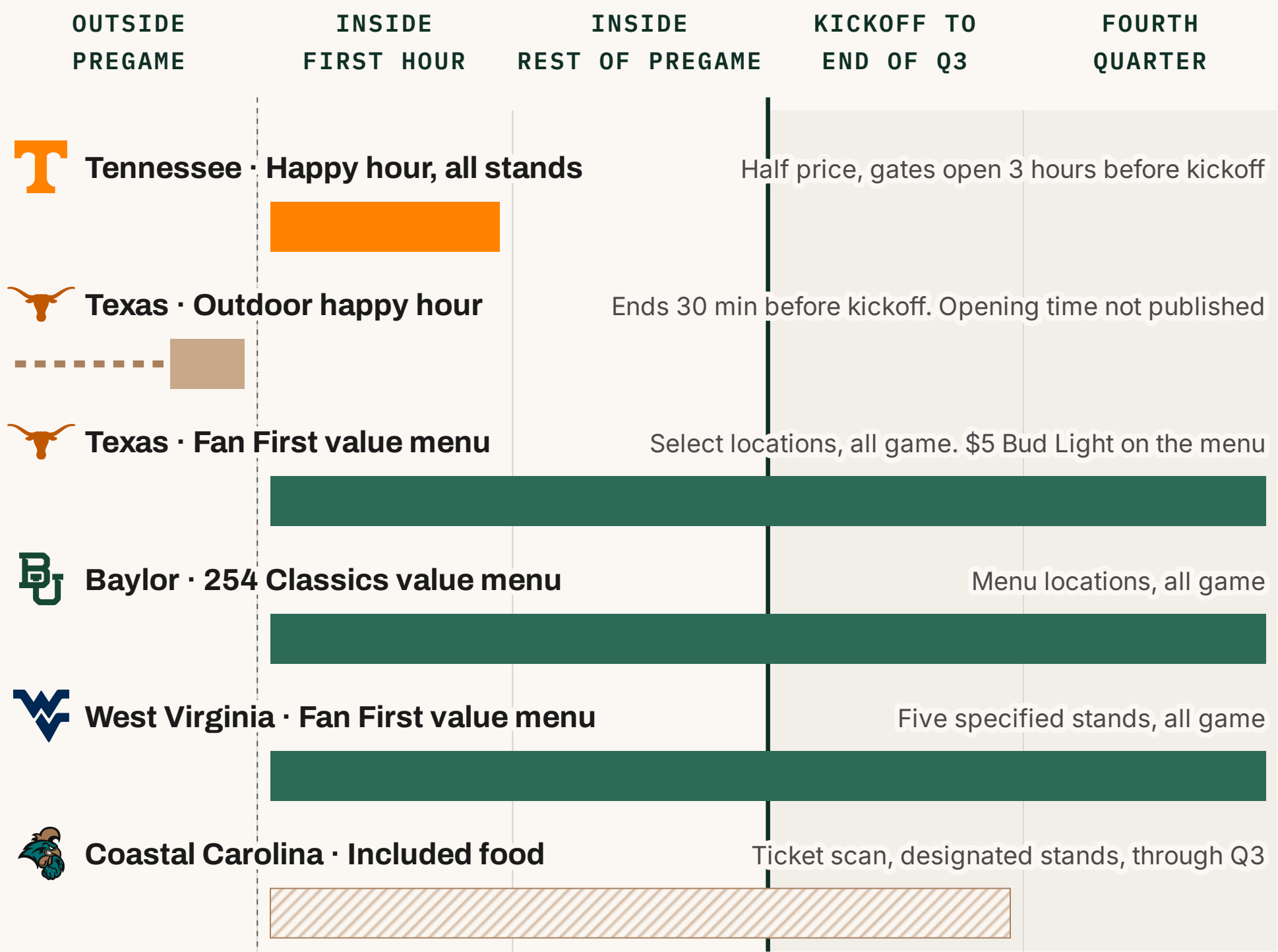
HOW TO READ IT

Value menu prices for hot dogs, popcorn, soft drinks and beer at four schools. Hatched bars mark the items Coastal Carolina includes with the ticket.

Sources: Texas Athletics gameday concessions (beer prices accessed Oct 1, 2026); Baylor 254 Classics (Feb 18, 2026); WVU (Aug 13, 2026); Coastal Carolina (Aug 18, 2026). Sizes shown where published. WVU prices apply at five stands, portions may be smaller. Coastal items need a ticket scan, one each per visit.

When the discount applies

When in the game day each program applies, from outside the gates to the fourth quarter.



1 hr

Tennessee discount window

Tennessee's discount covers one phase, the first hour inside. The value menus run the whole game. Texas's outdoor happy hour ends 30 minutes before kickoff, outside the stadium.

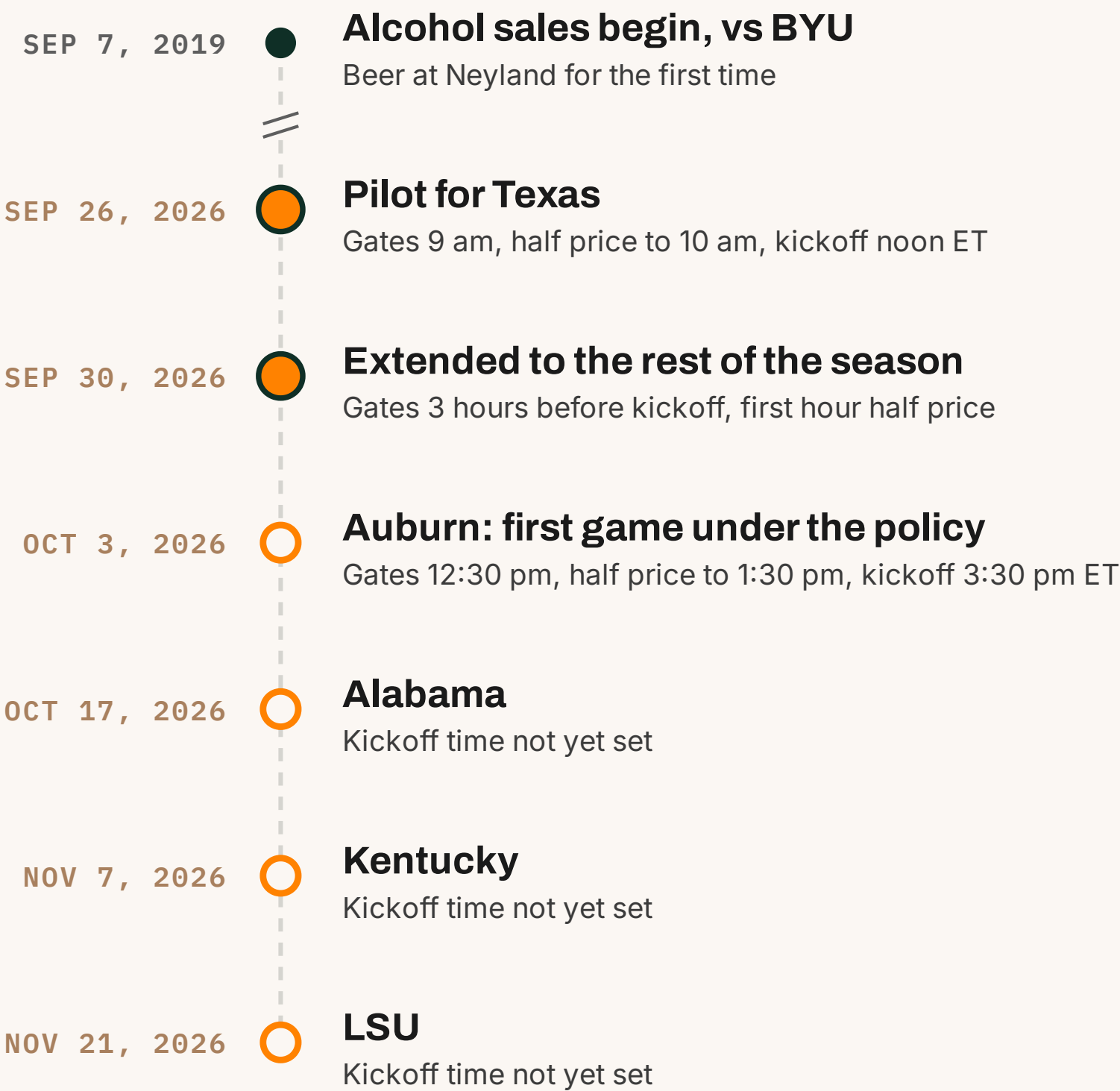
HOW TO READ IT

Each program drawn across five game phases, from outside before gates open to the fourth quarter. Phases replace clock times because several schools do not publish start times.

Sources: On3 (Sept 30, 2026); Texas Athletics gameday concessions; Baylor (Feb 18, 2026); WVU (Aug 13, 2026); Coastal Carolina (Aug 18, 2026). Shown by game phase, not clock time. Texas has not published an opening time for its outdoor happy hour.

From pilot to season policy

How Tennessee went from its first beer sales in 2019 to a first hour at half price this season.



4 days

from pilot to policy

Tennessee went from a single pilot game to a season policy in four days. Auburn on Oct 3 is the first game under the policy. Three home games still have no kickoff time.

HOW TO READ IT

Key dates from the first beer sales at Neyland in 2019 to the remaining 2026 home games, with gate and discount times where they are published.

Sources: Tennessee Athletics (Aug 16, 2019; 2026 schedule); On3 (Sept 30, 2026). All times Eastern. Alabama, Kentucky and LSU kickoff times were not set as of Oct 1, 2026.

Neyland alcohol sales in 2025

What Neyland sold in alcohol in 2025, and how the revenue is split.

\$4.3M

Gross alcohol sales, rounded

REPORTED

\$614,966

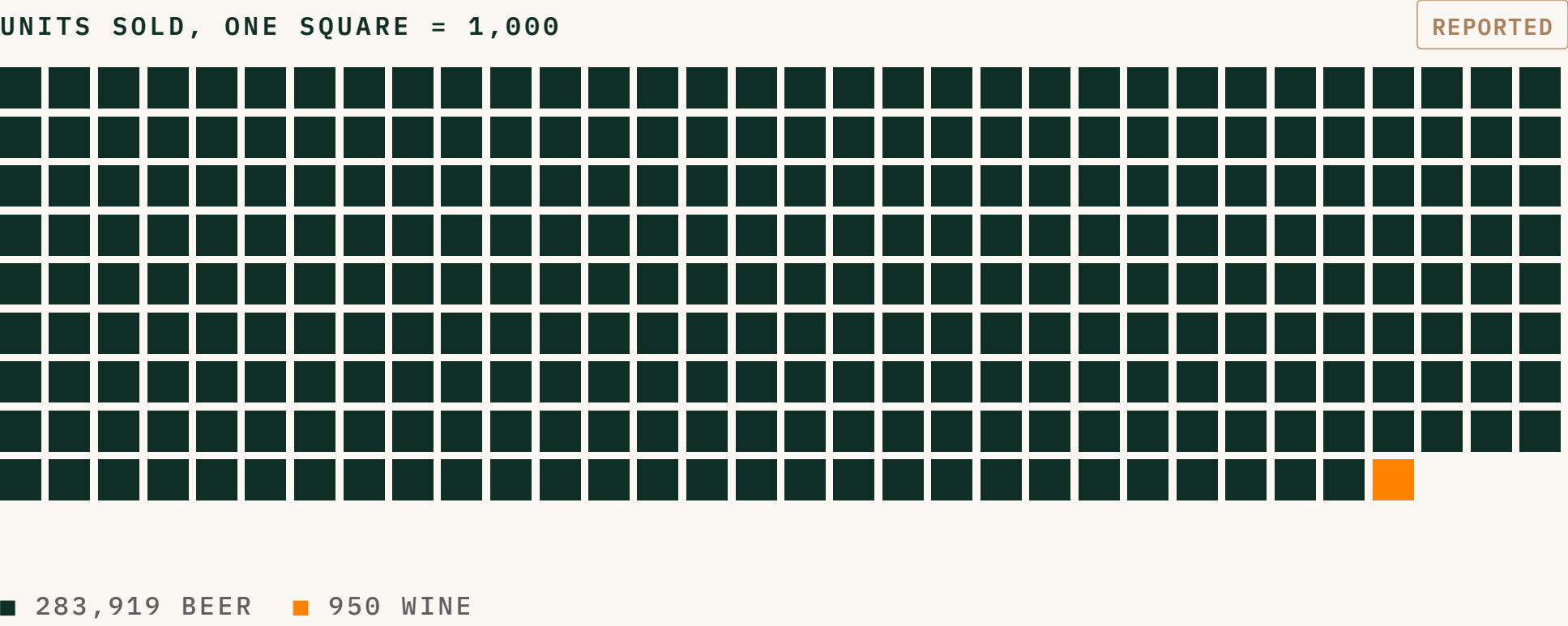
Average per game, 7 home games

REPORTED

≈\$15.09

Revenue per unit, beer and wine blended

CALCULATED



Revenue share, not net profit. Cost allocation is not public.

≈\$615K

alcohol sales per home game

Neyland sold 284,869 units for about \$4.3M, or about \$615K per home game. Beer was more than 99% of units. Each side's ≈\$2.15M is a revenue share, not profit.

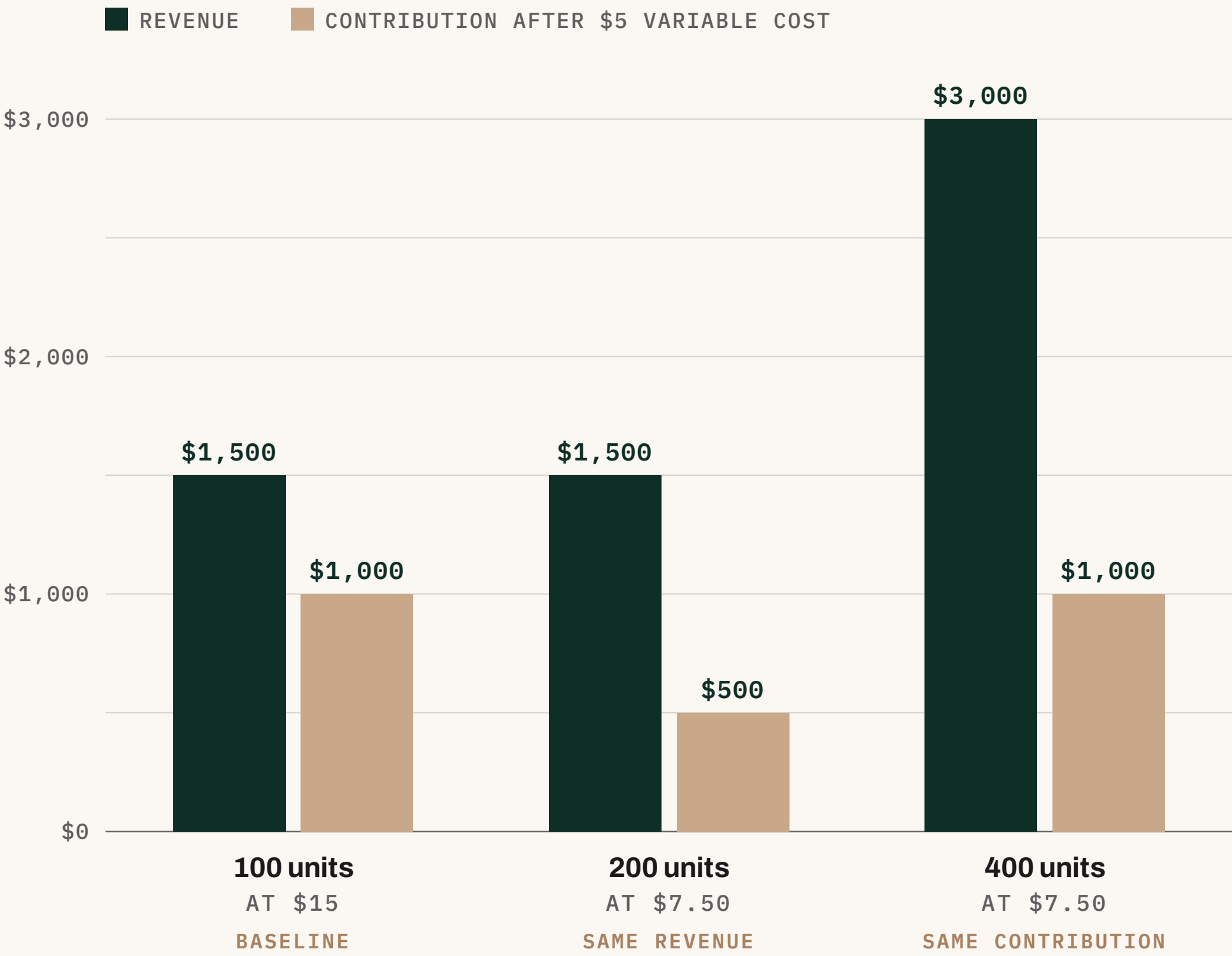
HOW TO READ IT

Reported 2025 alcohol revenue and units at Neyland, one square per 1,000 units, and the 50/50 revenue split with the concessionaire.

Source: Sports Business Journal (Mar 3, 2026) citing Knoxville News records. \$4.3M is rounded. Revenue per unit and the allocation are calculated from rounded figures. Revenue share is not net profit.

Half price, twice the sales

How many more units a discount hour has to sell to match results at full price.



4x

units to hold contribution

Matching revenue at half price takes 200 units. Matching contribution takes 400, because each discounted unit earns \$2.50 instead of \$10.

HOW TO READ IT

Revenue and contribution for 100 units at \$15, next to the volume needed at \$7.50 to match each one, using a \$5 cost per unit.

Illustrative: \$15 regular price, 50% discount, \$5 variable cost per unit, 100 baseline units. Not Tennessee's actual prices or costs.

The cost determines breakeven volume

How the cost of each unit changes the volume a discount needs.



\$7.50

cost where breakeven disappears

The multiple climbs as cost rises: 2.25x at \$1.50, 4x at \$5, 6x at \$6. At \$7.50 or more, every discounted unit loses money.

HOW TO READ IT

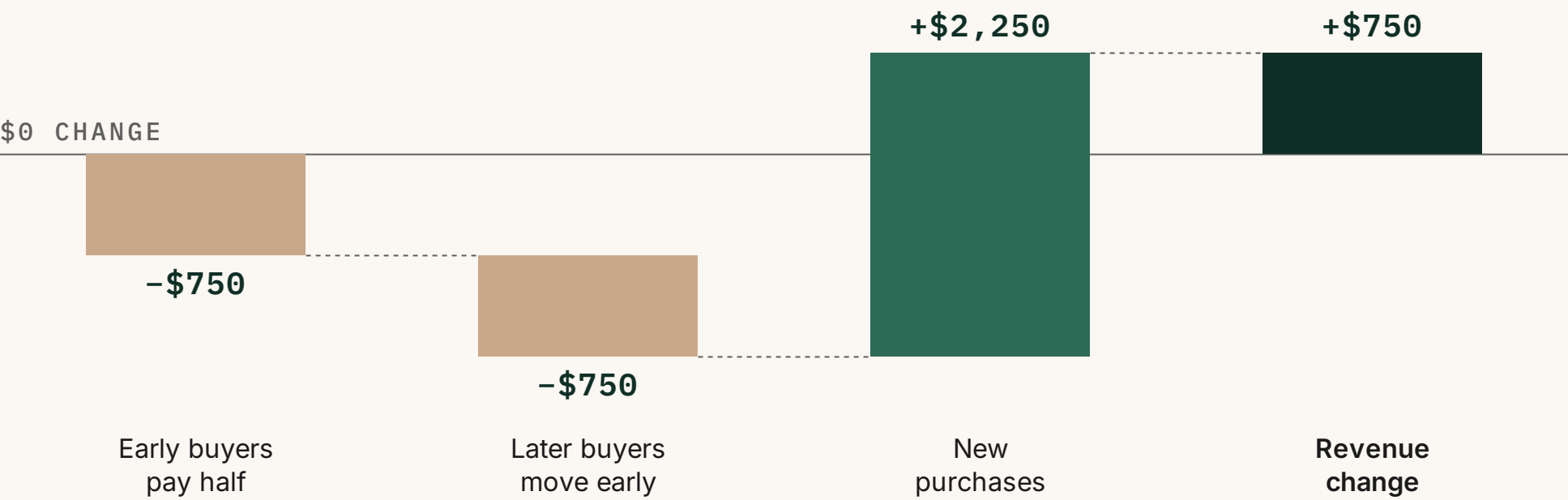
How many times the volume at full price a discount hour needs to hold contribution, at variable costs from \$1.50 to \$9 per unit.

Illustrative: \$15 regular price, \$7.50 discounted price. Contribution multiple = regular contribution per unit ÷ discounted contribution per unit. Not Tennessee's actual costs.

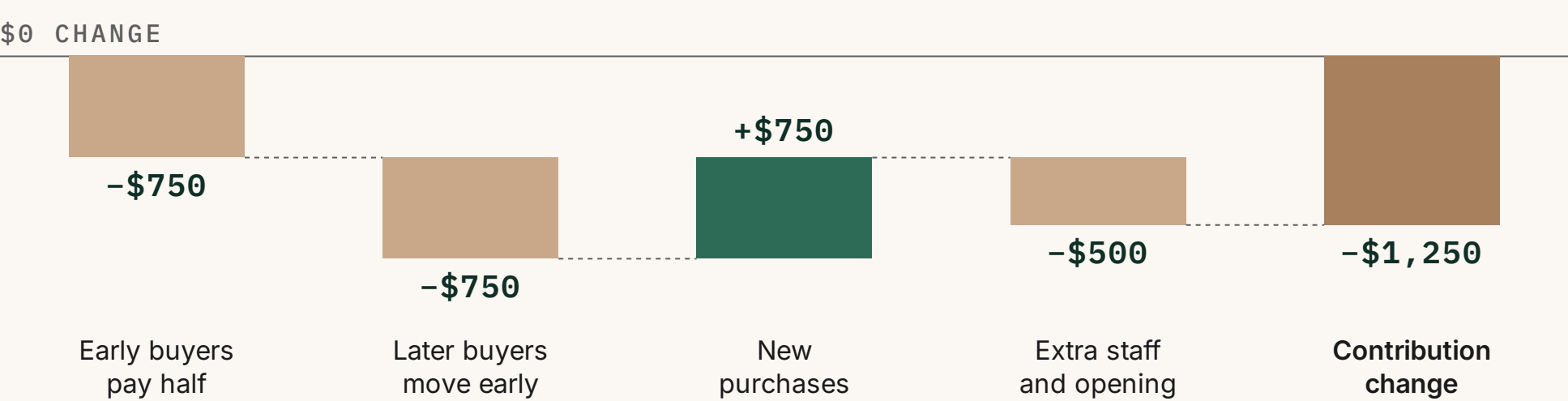
Where the extra spending comes from

Where the gains and losses come from when a game adds a discount hour.

REVENUE: \$15,000 BASELINE GAME



CONTRIBUTION: \$10,000 BASELINE GAME



-\$1,250

contribution change

Revenue rises \$750 and contribution falls \$1,250. New purchases have to outweigh the discount given to fans who would have bought anyway, plus the cost of opening earlier.

HOW TO READ IT

Revenue and contribution change for a game with 1,000 baseline units, split into early buyers paying half, later buyers moving early, new purchases and extra operating cost.

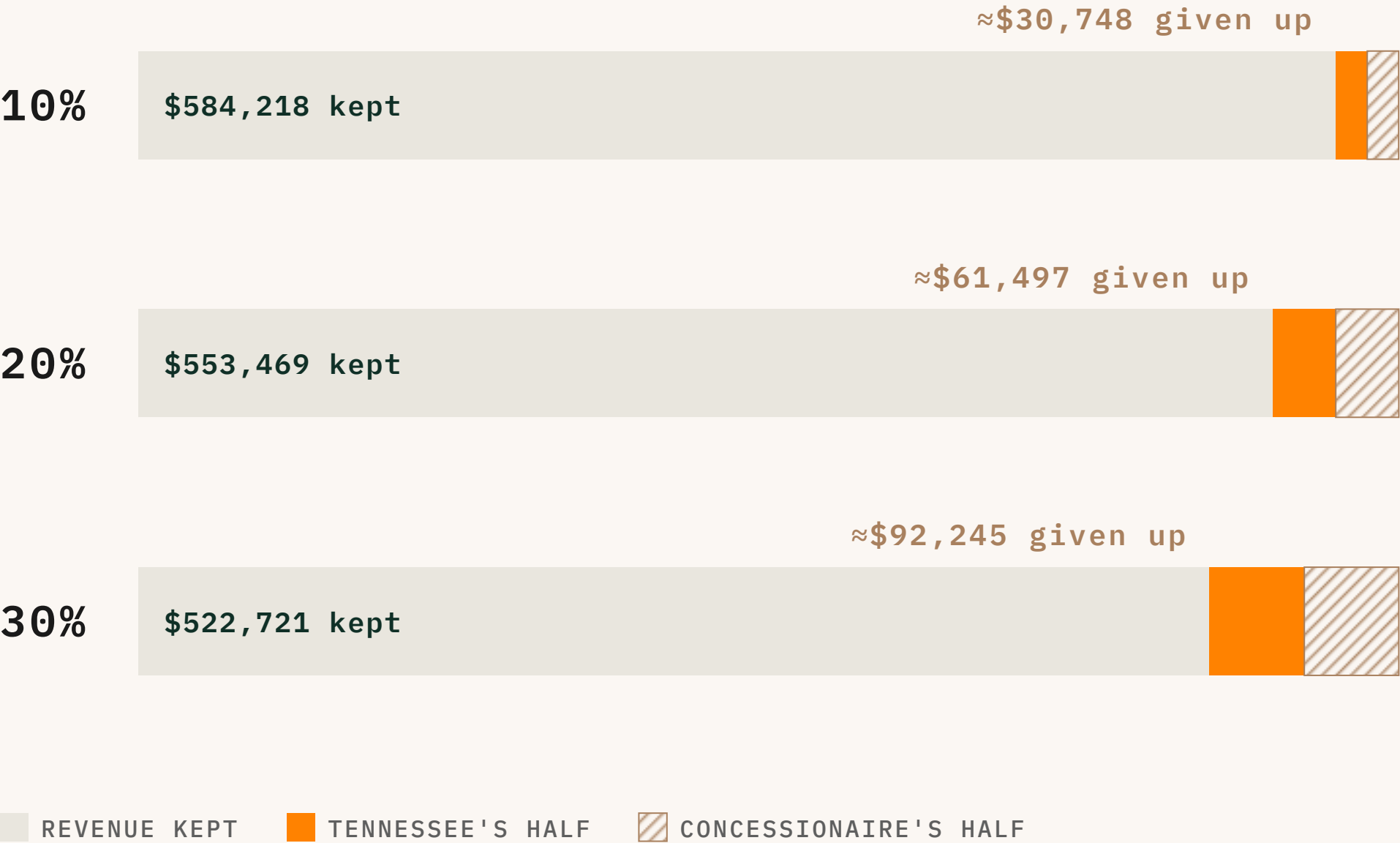
Illustration: 1,000 baseline units, 10% already bought early, 10% move from later in the game, 30% new, \$500 extra operating cost, \$15 price, \$5 cost. Not observed Tennessee behavior.

How much does the discount give up?

What a discount hour gives up if it brings in no new sales.

Average 2025 game: \$614,966 in alcohol sales

SHARE OF UNITS SOLD AT HALF PRICE



≈\$31K

per game for each 10% of units

Each 10% of units sold at half price gives up about \$31K a game before costs.

Under the 50/50 split, Tennessee absorbs half of it.

HOW TO READ IT

The 2025 average Neyland game, \$614,966 in alcohol sales, with 10%, 20% or 30% of units sold at half price and no added volume.

Illustrative: 50% price cut applied to the reported 2025 average of \$614,966 per game. Assumes the same average price across units, unchanged volume and a 50/50 allocation. Excludes costs.

What earlier experiments found

What one NFL venue and two schools reported after changing their pricing.



Atlanta Falcons
Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Fan First pricing

+16%
Spending per fan, 2017 vs 2016

6,000+
More fans per game entered earlier, first season

15%
Bottom line improvement as reported, 2018 vs 2017

Limit: *New stadium and other operating changes in the same period.*



Coastal Carolina
Brooks Stadium, food included with a ticket

22,217
Record crowd, Sept 6, 2025

3
Top 10 crowds in the 2025 rollout season

Limit: *Opponent and other effects are not separated.*



Texas
DKR, Fan First value menu since 2018

30%
Average price cut on 10 core items at launch, 2018

\$28
Gameday meal for a family of four at launch

9
Consecutive seasons, still running in 2026

Limit: *Price levels, not a measured sales or arrival result.*

+16%
Atlanta spend per fan, 2017

Atlanta reported 16% higher spend per fan and 6,000+ more fans entering earlier. Each result came alongside other changes, so none isolates the effect of price.

HOW TO READ IT

Results three programs published about themselves: Atlanta's Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Coastal Carolina and Texas, each with the main limit on what it proves. Texas reports price levels rather than sales results.

Sources: Mercedes-Benz Stadium (fan survey release; second price cut release); Coastal Carolina Athletics (Aug 18, 2026); Texas Athletics (Aug 6, 2018; Aug 21, 2026). Figures reported by the venue and schools.

What pulls each fan inside

Which fans a discount hour is most likely to bring in early, and which it is not.

FAN	WHAT COULD MOVE THEM	PULL
Tailgater Time with friends, drinks already bought	Something in the bowl they would miss: warmups, the band's pregame show, a gate giveaway	LOW
Early arriver Comes for the bowl filling, warmups and the band	Already early. The discount mostly cuts the price of purchases they would make anyway	LOW
Value seeker Price and convenience: families, shuttle riders, fans who skip the tailgate	Most likely to change arrival time for a discount	HIGH
CONSTRAINT	Security lines slow arrival for every fan, whatever the price. At Tennessee's Sept 26 pilot against Texas, Secret Service screening at Neyland made a late arrival risky, so that game is a weak read on the discount alone.	

1 of 3

fan groups likely to move

Value seekers are the group most likely to move. Tailgaters already paid for their drinks, and early arrivers get a cheaper version of purchases they would make anyway.

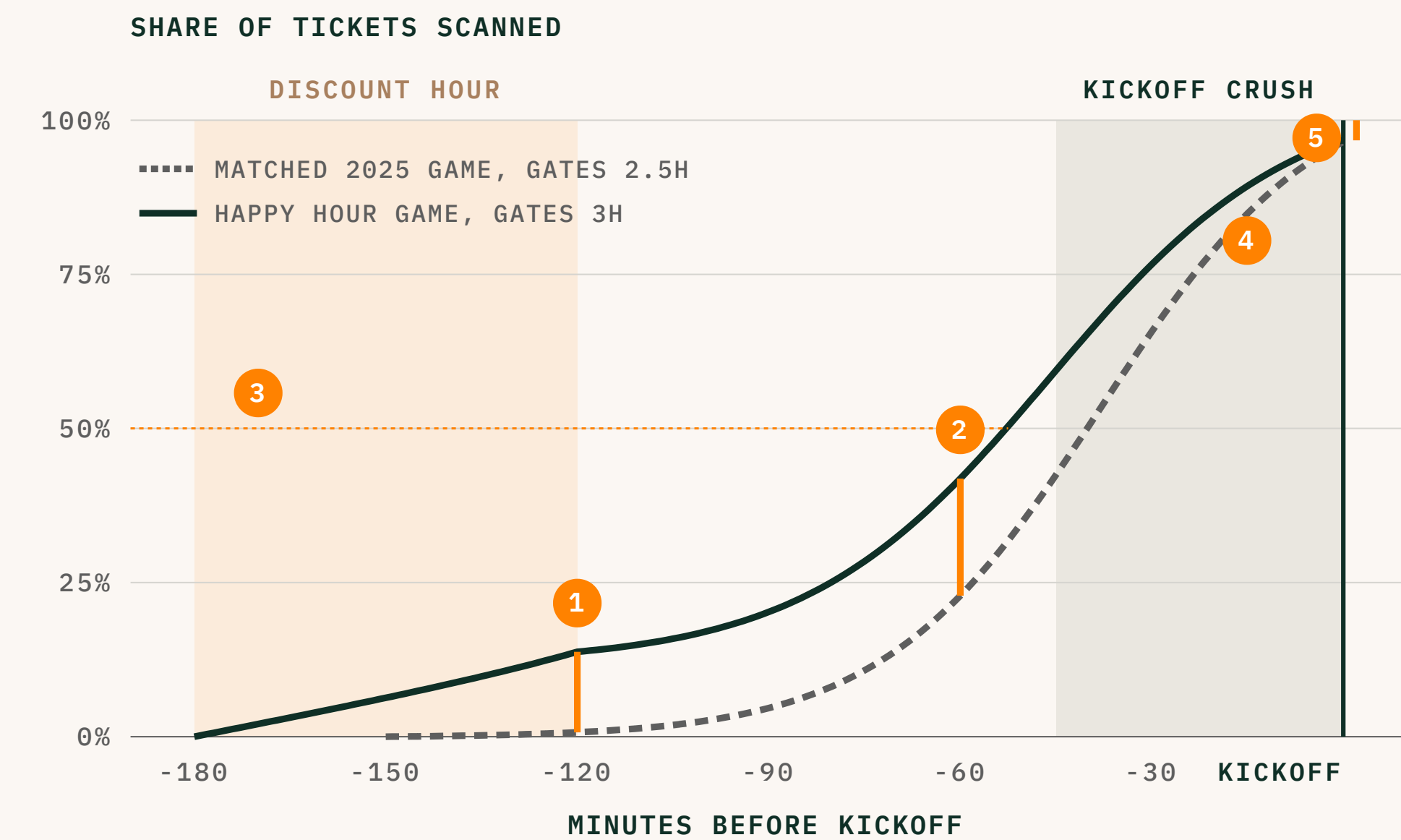
HOW TO READ IT

Three fan groups, what could change when they enter, and our rating of how strongly a discount hour pulls each one. The band at the foot covers security lines, which slow every fan.

Playbook Strategies analysis. Fan groups and pull ratings are hypotheses to test with gate scans, purchase data and a postgame survey, not measured behavior. Sept 26 pilot context: Tennessee Athletics and On3 (Sept 2026).

Reading the scan curve

How gate scans can show whether fans arrive earlier.



- 1

Share in by the end of the discount hour
- 2

Share in an hour before kickoff
- 3

Median scan time
- 4

Peak scans per gate per minute in the last 45 minutes
- 5

Share not yet in at kickoff

5

readings to take

If the policy works, the solid line rises earlier and the kickoff crush shrinks. The first reading is the share of fans scanned by the end of the discount hour.

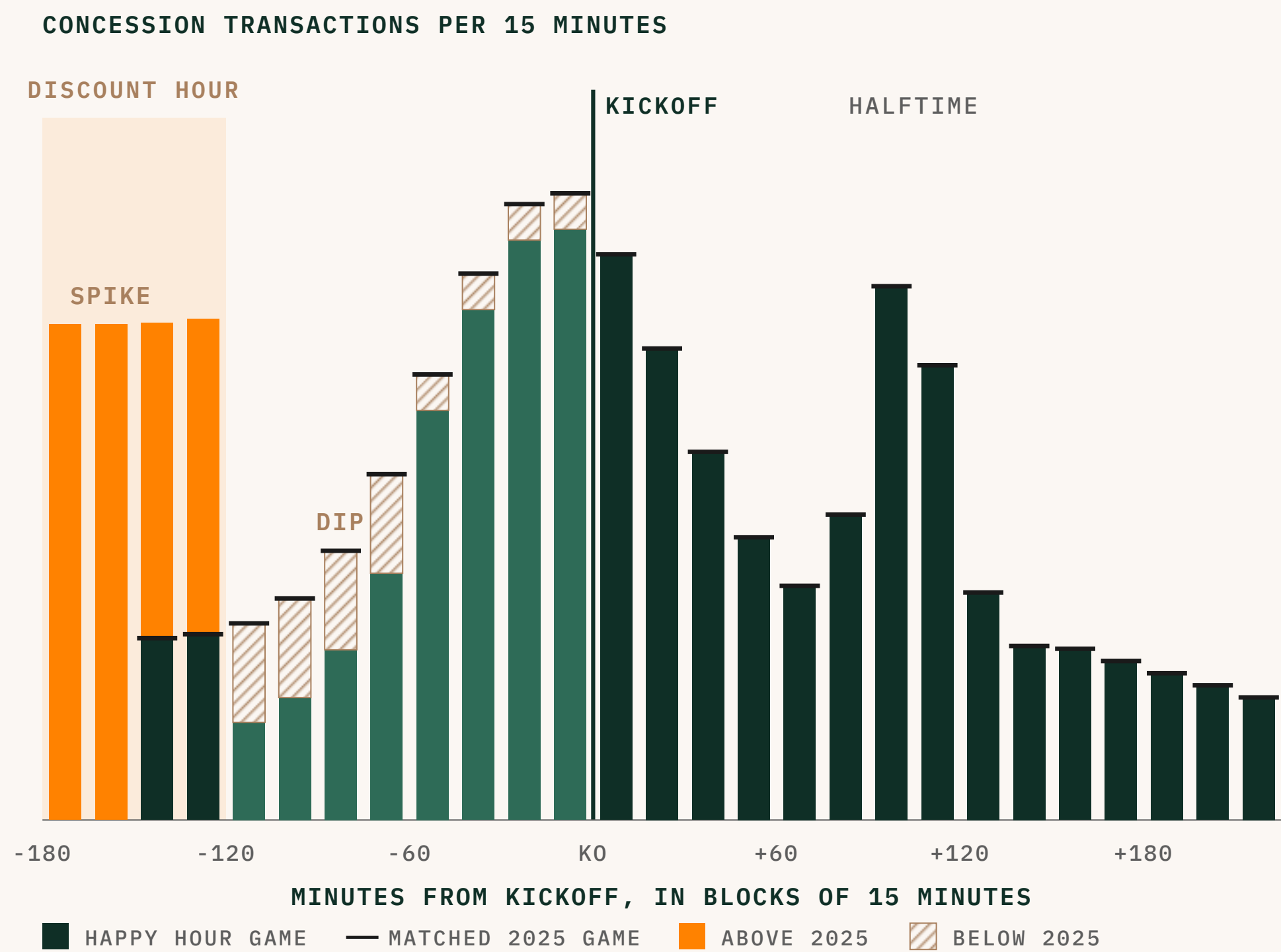
HOW TO READ IT

An example of cumulative ticket scans by minute before kickoff, comparing a happy hour game with a matched 2025 game. The numbered points are the five readings to take.

Illustrative curve shapes, not Tennessee data. Gates 2.5 hours before kickoff in 2025 and 3 hours in 2026 (UT game day release, Nov 2025; On3, Sept 30, 2026). Compare each game with the closest 2025 game by kickoff slot, opponent and weather.

Reading the purchase curve

How sales by 15 minute block can show whether spending grew or only moved earlier.



15 min

sales blocks to compare

A first hour spike followed by dips means purchases moved earlier. The policy adds revenue only if the game total beats the matched game.

HOW TO READ IT

An example of transactions per 15 minutes from gates open to the fourth quarter, with a matched 2025 game outlined. Orange marks purchases above 2025; hatching marks purchases below it.

Illustrative shapes, not Tennessee data. Read with point of sale data by item, stand and 15 minute window. Neyland is cashless, so card data can also show repeat purchases by first hour buyers.

What would show it worked

The metrics, data sources and signals that would show a program worked.

NEEDLE	METRIC	SOURCE	SIGNAL IT WORKED
ARRIVAL	Share of fans scanned an hour before kickoff	Gate scans by 15 minutes	Higher than the matched game
	Peak scans per gate per minute, last 45 min	Gate scans	Lower peak, shorter lines
SPEND	Revenue and units per scanned fan, full game	Point of sale	Higher across the full game
	Purchases after the discount hour	Point of sale by 15 minutes	No dip below the 2025 shape
	First hour buyers who buy again later	Card transactions	Repeat purchases rise
MARGIN	Contribution after product, labor and the extra hour	Finance and labor logs	Above the matched game
FAN	Why fans arrived when they did, and whether they tailgated	Postgame survey	Discount named as a reason
RISK	Alcohol incidents, ejections, medical calls by time block	Stadium operations	No rise in early blocks

COMPARISON

Each 2026 game against the closest 2025 game by kickoff slot, opponent and weather.

1 hr

before kickoff: the first read

No single number settles it. Arrival, spend per fan across the game and contribution need to improve together against a matched 2025 game, with a survey to explain why.

HOW TO READ IT

The metrics to track, grouped by arrival, spend, margin, fan and risk, with the data source and the signal that would count as success for each.

Playbook Strategies measurement plan. Data needed: gate scans, item and location sales, unique buyers, labor and cost of goods, queue times. No results are implied.

What this means for a pricing program

Five lessons for any school weighing a concession pricing program.

01 **Decide the job first.**

A happy hour moves spending earlier. A value menu lowers the price of the basics all game. Each needs its own measure.

02 **Price the hour on contribution.**

Half price needs twice the units to hold revenue. At a \$5 cost per unit it needs four times the units to hold contribution, so know your cost per unit before you set the discount.

03 **Expect only some fans to move.**

Tailgaters and early arrivers change little. Families, shuttle riders and fans who skip the tailgate are the most likely to come in for a discount.

04 **Measure arrival and spend across the game together.**

Compare each game with a matched 2025 game. A busy first hour with no gain in the game total means purchases moved earlier.

05 **Read the Sept 26 pilot with care.**

Secret Service screening at Neyland changed arrival for the Texas game. Auburn on Oct 3 is the first game under the policy.



Method and sources

How the figures were sourced, calculated and labeled.

Data as of October 1, 2026. All times Eastern.

STATUS TAGS ON EACH PAGE

REPORTED	Published by a school, venue or news outlet.
CALCULATED	Derived from reported figures. Marked ≈ where rounded.
ILLUSTRATIVE	Example numbers that show the mechanics. Not Tennessee data.
PROGRAM REPORTED	Results a venue or school published about its own program. Not independently verified.
ANALYSIS • HYPOTHESIS	Playbook Strategies judgment, to be tested with scan, sales and survey data.
MEASUREMENT PLAN	Metrics we propose to track. No results are implied.

THE ILLUSTRATION

PAGES 8 AND 9	\$15 regular price, 50% discount to \$7.50, \$5 variable cost per unit, 100 baseline units.
PAGE 10	1,000 baseline units. 10% were already bought early, 10% move from later in the game, 30% are new purchases. \$500 extra cost for staff and the earlier opening.
PAGE 11	A 50% cut on 10%, 20% or 30% of units, applied to the reported 2025 average of \$614,966 per game. Same average price across units, no added volume, 50/50 allocation, costs excluded.

\$4.3M is a rounded total, so unit and allocation figures are approximate. Revenue share is not net profit; the cost split between Tennessee and its concessionaire is not public. Kickoff times for Alabama, Kentucky and LSU were not set at publication.

SOURCES

On3, "Danny White puts Happy Hour at Neyland Stadium into effect for remainder of season" (Sept 30, 2026)
Tennessee Athletics: beer and wine sales announcement (Aug 16, 2019); 2026 football schedule; game day release (Nov 2025)
Sports Business Journal (Mar 3, 2026), citing Knox News records of Neyland alcohol sales
Texas Athletics: Fan First pricing launch (Aug 6, 2018); gameday concessions; Sodexo Live 2026 season release (Aug 21, 2026); Forty Acres Insider (Sept 1, 2026)
Baylor Athletics: 254 Classics value menu (Feb 18, 2026)
West Virginia Athletics: value menu (Aug 13, 2026)
Coastal Carolina Athletics: food included with tickets (Aug 18, 2026)
12th Man Foundation, Texas A&M (Aug 31, 2026)
South Carolina Athletics (Aug 20, 2026)
Mercedes-Benz Stadium: Fan First fan survey release; second price reduction release



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